

Letter to Student Union President re Dougal MacDonald

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Akanksha Bhatnagar
President, University of Alberta Students' Union
Room 2-900
Students' Union Building
University of Alberta
8900 – 114 Street NW
Edmonton, AB
T6G 2J7

Dear Akanksha,

We are very concerned about the statement issued by the Students' Union at the University of Alberta in regard to Dr. Dougal MacDonald, who teaches in the Faculty of Education.

Your condemnation of Dr. MacDonald's remarks on the Holodomor and demand that he take them back or resign are incompatible with the University's policies and principles on Freedom of Expression. Just this week the General Faculties Council approved the University's new statement on Freedom of Expression which reads:

The university is a place of free and open inquiry in all matters, and all members of the university community have the broadest possible latitude to speak, write, listen, view, challenge, profess, and learn. Members of the university community have the right to criticize and question other views expressed on our campuses, but may not obstruct or otherwise interfere with others' freedom of expression. Debate or deliberation may not be suppressed because the ideas put forward are thought by some, or even most, to be offensive, unwise, immoral, or misguided. It is for individuals, not the institution, to make those judgments for themselves and to act not by seeking to suppress expression, but by openly and vigorously contesting the ideas they oppose. The university does not attempt to shield members of the university community from ideas or opinions they disagree with or find offensive.

Dr. MacDonald's remarks are protected by our *Charter of Rights and Freedoms* as well as by the academic freedom to extramural expression that is a necessary right of all academic staff at the University. As the statement notes, in the University the proper response to ideas with which we do not agree is rigorous debate with those ideas, not their suppression.

The learning environment is not, as your statement implies, made "safe" when any individual or group attempts to prevent another's exercise of freedom of expression. It is fundamentally undermined, as the ability to examine, analyze, and critique all ideas is the lifeblood of the University.

Sincerely,

Lise Gotell, Professor, Women's & Gender Studies
Carolyn Sale, Associate Professor, English & Film Studies
James Muir, Associate Dean Research, Faculty of Law
Julie Rak, Professor & HM Tory Chair, English & Film Studies
Danielle Fuller, Professor, English & Film Studies

Ricardo Acuña, Executive Director, Parkland Institute, Faculty of Arts
 Ryan Dunch, Professor and Chair, History and Classics
 Kathleen Lowrey, Associate Professor, Anthropology
 Christopher Lupke, Chair, East Asian Studies
 Phillip Choi, Ph.D., P.Eng., F.C.I.C., F.E.I.C., Professor, Department of Chemical and Materials Engineering
 Natalie Loveless, Associate Professor and Associate Chair, Undergraduate, Department of Art and Design
 Andrew Holt, Associate Professor, Department of Psychiatry
 Jennifer L. Branch-Mueller, Professor, Department of Elementary Education
 José da Costa, Professor of Educational Administration and Leadership, Faculty of Education
 Laurie Adkin, Professor, Department of Political Science
 Craig Heinke, Professor, Department of Physics
 Frank Elliott, Adjunct Assistant Professor, Department of Secondary Education
 Dennis Sweeney, Associate Professor, History and Classics
 Michelle Noga, Associate Professor, Faculty of Medicine and Dentistry
 Steven Khan, Assistant Professor, Faculty of Education
 Karim Jamal PhD, FCPA, FCA, CA Distinguished Professor, Chair, Department of Accounting, Operations and Information Systems (AOIS), School of Business
 David Jay, Visiting Professor, Department of Music
 Maciej Bukczynski, Sessional Lecturer, School of Business
 Suping Song, Directrice, École de langues du Campus Saint-Jean
 Khalid Aziz, Professor, Faculty of Medicine & Dentistry
 Corwin Sullivan, Associate Professor, Faculty of Science
 David E. Rast, Assistant Professor, Department of Psychology
 Michelle Meagher, Associate Professor & Chair, Department of Women's and Gender Studies
 Tara Milbrandt, Associate Professor of Sociology, Augustana
 Anne-José Villeneuve, Assistant Professor, Campus Saint-Jean
 Stu White, Assistant Chair, Administration, Anthropology & Economics
 Olga Petrovskaya, Assistant Professor, Faculty of Nursing
 Vijay Daniels, Associate Professor, Faculty of Medicine and Dentistry
 Alsu Kuznetsova, Research Associate, Department of Renewable Resources
 João Soares, Department of Chemical and Materials Engineering
 Lia Daniels, Professor, Faculty of Education
 Peter Kuznetsov, Research Associate, CEE
 Patricia Paradis, Executive Director, Centre for Constitutional Studies/Centre d'études constitutionnelles
 Greg Ash, Associate Director, Fund Information and Accounting, Office of Advancement
 Cynthia Palmaria, Faculty, Department of Oncology, Faculty of Medicine and Dentistry
 Audrey Hodgson-Ward, Elementary Education
 Damián Cirelli, Faculty of Science Instructor, Department of Biological Sciences
 David Kennedy, Associate Professor, Department of Drama
Additional Signatures:
 Bill Beard, Professor, English & Film Studies
 Erin Pollock, Associate Lecturer, School of Public Health

Victoria Ruetalo, Associate Professor, Spanish and Latin American Studies
Makere Stewart-Harawira, Professor, Educational Policy Studies
Jaimie Baron, Associate Professor, English & Film Studies
Janice Williamson, Professor Emerita, Department of English & Film Studies
Geri Lorway, Assistant Lecturer, Elementary Education
Adam Kemezis, Associate Professor, History & Classics
Tony Simmons, Associate Professor, Sociology, Athabasca University
Don Carmichael, Professor Emeritus, Political Science
Joseph M. Kirman, Professor Emeritus, Department of Elementary Education